Haligric Research Integration Series

The Unity of Humankind

A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

The Sacred Tradition of the Bahá’í Faith, Founded by Bahá’u'lláh in Nineteenth-Century Persia

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In 1863, in a garden outside Baghdad, a Persian nobleman told a small circle of followers that he was the messenger God had promised through an earlier prophet, executed thirteen years before. From that declaration grew a religion with no clergy, no priests, and a founding claim that every major faith before it had been true — each one a chapter of the same unfinished book.

Today it counts some five to eight million adherents in nearly every country on earth, governed by elected councils rather than an ordained hierarchy, gathering every nineteen days to pray, deliberate, and share a meal together as equals.

Its central shrine sits in gardens in northern Israel that UNESCO now protects as a World Heritage Site.

In the country of its birth, believing it remains, to this day, a documented and prosecutable crime.

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Introduction — Progressive Revelation and the Unity of Humankind

The Bahá'í Faith is an independent world religion founded in nineteenth-century Persia (present-day Iran), today practiced by an estimated five to eight million adherents across nearly every country on earth, making it one of the most geographically widespread religions in the world despite its comparatively recent founding and modest total membership relative to the largest global faiths.

The Bahá'í Faith has no ordained clergy or priesthood; religious and administrative authority instead rests with democratically elected Local, National, and ultimately international Spiritual Assemblies, a structure explicitly designed by the religion's founders to prevent the kind of clerical hierarchy and doctrinal schism they regarded as having repeatedly fractured earlier world religions.

Origins — The Báb and Bahá’u'lláh

The Bahá’í Faith traces its origin to the Bábí movement founded in 1844 by Siyyid ʿAlí Muhammad of Shiraz, who took the title the Báb ('the Gate') and announced that he was the herald of a coming messenger of God greater than himself. The Báb was executed by Iranian authorities in 1850, and severe persecution of his followers followed; among the imprisoned Bábís was Mírzá Ḥusayn-ʿAlí Núrí, who in 1863, in the Ridván Garden outside Baghdad shortly before his forced relocation by Ottoman authorities to Constantinople, declared to his fellow believers that he was the messenger of God foretold by the Báb, taking the title Bahá’u'lláh ('the Glory of God').

Bahá’u'lláh spent much of the remainder of his life in successive exiles and imprisonments across the Ottoman Empire, ultimately settling under continued confinement near Akka (Acre), in present-day Israel, where he died in 1892 after authoring the bulk of the religion's core scripture, including its central book of laws.

Theology — Progressive Revelation and Sacred Text

Central Bahá’í theology holds that God is fundamentally unknowable in essence but has revealed himself progressively throughout human history through a succession of divine messengers or 'Manifestations of God' — including, in Bahá’í teaching, Abraham, Moses, Buddha, Krishna, Zoroaster, Jesus, and Muhammad, with the Báb and Bahá’u'lláh as the most recent in this line — each bringing teachings suited to the needs and capacity of their particular time and place, rather than any one revelation being final or exclusively true. From this theology of progressive revelation follows the faith's foundational social principle: the essential unity of all religions and the unity of the entire human race, with the elimination of racial, class, national, and religious prejudice treated as a direct religious obligation rather than merely an ethical preference.

The Kitáb-i-Aqdas ('Most Holy Book'), written by Bahá’u'lláh, functions as the religion's central book of laws, alongside a substantial additional body of his writings, those of the Báb, and those of Bahá’u'lláh's son and appointed successor, ʿAbdu'l-Bahá, which together constitute the faith's full sacred literature.

Sacred Institutions and Key Figures

ʻAbdu'l-Bahá, Bahá’u'lláh's eldest son, served as his father's authorized successor and sole authoritative interpreter of Bahá’í scripture from 1892 until his own death in 1921, and undertook extensive travels through Europe and North America explaining and establishing the faith internationally. Shoghi Effendi, ʻAbdu'l-Bahá's grandson, served as Guardian of the Bahá’í Faith from 1921 to 1957, substantially developing both its global administrative structure and much of its English-language interpretive literature, including his widely cited description of the Nineteen-Day Fast as a period of meditation and spiritual recuperation.

The Universal House of Justice, the faith's supreme governing institution, has been elected every five years since 1963 by delegates from every National Spiritual Assembly worldwide, convening in Haifa, Israel; per Bahá’í law, its election proceeds entirely without nomination, campaigning, or factional organizing of any kind. As of the early twenty-first century, the faith maintains more than 180 National Spiritual Assemblies and several thousand Local Spiritual Assemblies worldwide, alongside a small number of formally consecrated Houses of Worship on multiple continents, including in the United States, India, Australia, Uganda, Panama, Samoa, and Chile.

The Bahá’í Calendar and the Nineteen Day Feast

The Bahá’í calendar, originally established by the Báb, consists of nineteen months of nineteen days each (totaling 361 days), with four or five additional intercalary days (Ayyám-i-Há) inserted before the final month to align the calendar with the solar year; the year begins at the spring equinox with the festival of Naw-Rúz.

On the first day of each of these nineteen-day months, local Bahá’í communities gather for the Nineteen Day Feast, structured in three sequential parts: a devotional portion of prayers and readings from Bahá’í scripture intended to elevate the spiritual atmosphere of the gathering; an administrative portion, open only to Bahá’ís, in which community members consult on local affairs and communicate directly with their Local Spiritual Assembly using a distinctive Bahá’í consultative method that emphasizes frank, non-adversarial deliberation; and a concluding social portion of shared refreshment and fellowship. The Feast functions simultaneously as spiritual practice, grassroots democratic governance, and community bonding, and while attendance is not formally compulsory, it is regarded within the tradition as both a privilege and a responsibility of community membership.

Self-Care, Wellness, and Daily Practice

Bahá'ís are required to perform one of three obligatory prayers daily, chosen according to personal preference, alongside a broader expectation of regular devotional reading and reflection; work performed in a spirit of service to humanity is explicitly elevated within Bahá'í teaching to the status of worship, a doctrine that shapes many adherents' approach to ordinary daily labor as spiritually meaningful rather than religiously neutral.

The Nineteen-Day Fast, observed during the final month of the Bahá'í calendar ('Alá', typically March 1-20, immediately preceding the Naw-Rúz new year), requires adult Bahá'ís between fifteen and seventy to abstain completely from food and drink between sunrise and sunset, with established exemptions for illness, pregnancy, nursing, menstruation, travel, and heavy physical labor. Shoghi Effendi described the fast's purpose explicitly as 'a period of meditation and prayer, of spiritual recuperation,' oriented toward detachment from selfish and material preoccupation rather than physical austerity for its own sake — a wellness practice understood as inseparable from spiritual renewal.

Pilgrimage and Sacred Sites

The Bahá'í Holy Places in Haifa and the Western Galilee, including the Shrine of the Báb on Mount Carmel with its terraced gardens, and the Shrine of Bahá'u'lláh at Bahji near Akka, were jointly inscribed as a UNESCO World Heritage Site in 2008, recognized as the administrative and spiritual center of the Bahá'í Faith and one of the most architecturally significant religious sites built anywhere in the world during the twentieth century.

Formal Bahá'í pilgrimage to these sites in Israel is considered a significant spiritual obligation for those able to undertake it, and the surrounding terraced gardens, maintained to an exacting horticultural standard, function as both an active place of prayer and a widely visited public attraction independent of their specifically religious significance.

Legacy and Influence

The Bahá’í administrative model — an ordained-clergy-free structure of elected councils operating by consultation rather than hierarchical decree, culminating in a supreme body elected without campaigning or factions — is frequently cited in comparative religious studies as one of the most distinctive institutional innovations among modern new religious movements, and the faith's core social principles (racial unity, universal education including gender equality in education, and the harmony of science and religion) have been influential well beyond its own membership in twentieth-century interfaith and human-rights discourse.

The faith's substantial community-level social and economic development programming, run through Bahá’í-affiliated organizations worldwide, is frequently cited by international development bodies as a notable example of grassroots, locally led development work rooted explicitly in religious conviction rather than secular NGO practice.

Persecution in Iran — Controversies and Fairness

As the birthplace of the Bahá’í Faith and the site of its founders' imprisonment and exile, Iran has also been the site of the religion's most severe and sustained persecution since the 1979 Islamic Revolution, under a policy Human Rights Watch traces to a 1991 memorandum attributed to Iran's Supreme Leader that explicitly directs the systematic suppression of Bahá’í community life, education, and economic activity. Bahá’ís in Iran are denied constitutional recognition as a religious minority, barred from higher education, and routinely excluded from government employment.

A Human Rights Watch report released December 10, 2025, documented a sharp escalation in this persecution: the Bahá’í International Community recorded more than 750 documented persecutory acts between June and November 2025 alone, roughly triple the equivalent period in 2024, including more than 200 raids on homes and businesses, at least 110 arrests, and over 100 new criminal convictions carrying sentences of two to ten years — with courts in some cases reopening previously acquitted cases specifically to impose harsher sentences on retrial. Property confiscation under Iran's constitutional Article 49, invoked to seize homes, vehicles, and bank accounts on the premise that Bahá’í-held assets are inherently 'illegal,' has also intensified, with one Isfahan case alone affecting twenty individuals. The European Union imposed sanctions on Iranian judicial officials in April 2025 specifically in response to this persecution, and the United Nations has repeatedly passed resolutions condemning it, though the practice continues as of this writing without resolution.

Closing

The Universal House of Justice still meets in Haifa, elected without campaigning or nomination, exactly as Bahá'u'lláh's writings prescribed a century and a half ago.

And in Iran, as of a Human Rights Watch report from December 2025, Bahá'ís are still being arrested, stripped of their property, and sentenced to years in prison for the same faith practiced openly by millions elsewhere in the world.

Grand rising to the people of the unity of humankind — the persecution their founder foresaw has not yet ended, and neither has the religion he founded.